

THE IMMORTAL FIVE

There is a certain sense of uncertainty for players in the build-up to a World Cup. A whole four years are at their disposal to score, assist, defend and do everything possible to get into that squad that earns the right to wear the badge on their chest. Thousands have done it, only a select few have truly owned football's grandest stage. As new generations prepare to chase glory, we revisit the legends who transformed the quadrennial spectacle into the *'greatest show on Earth'*.

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No player is as synonymous with the World Cup as Brazilian magician Pelé. His three titles back that claim.

The first of those came in 1958, when he took the tournament in Sweden by storm as a 17-year-old. Out injured for the first two fixtures, Pelé recovered to score in all of Brazil's knockout games, and remains the youngest player to score in a World Cup final after his brace against the host nation.

An injury in the first game of the 1962 tournament left a red-hot Pelé watching from the sidelines as Brazil defended its title in Chile. And despite being a two-time champion at 21, Pelé cemented his legendary status only later.

Tasked with retaining the title, Brazil was given a rude awakening as it crashed — or rather was 'kicked out' — by the aggressive Hungary and Portugal sides in the group stage in 1966. Pelé threatened to leave the national side, but reconsidered his decision for the next edition in Mexico, where he immortalised himself as one of the greats.

Performing at the peak of his powers, he scored or assisted in all six of Brazil's games, including the opener against Italy in the final. That team often wins the argument for being the best side in the competition's history, and at the centre of it all was Pelé, who finally wore the crown of *O Rei* (The King).

Pelé

